worse. Sometime in 1227, in an unknown camp south of the Li-p'an Mountains, the Universal Khan of the Mongols drew his last breath. His death was kept secret, by his own wish, until his generals finished demolishing the last Xia strongholds in September of 1227.[13]

HE LEFT HIS CONQUESTS, which stretched westward to the Caspian Sea and southward to the Hindu Kush mountains, to his sons.

Jochi had died a few months before his father, so the lands awarded to him—the western territories he had himself helped reduce—were divided between his two sons. Genghis Khan's youngest son Tolui received the Khan's own homeland. Chagatai, the second son, was given his father's lands in Central Asia.

The third son of the conqueror, Ogodei, received the title of Great Khan of the Mongols.

This had been Genghis Khan's own wish. He had fallen out with Jochi repeatedly, and he suspected that his second son Chagatai was unequal to the job: "As Genghis Khan was aware that his nature was excessively sanguinary, malevolent, and tyrannical," writes Juvaini, "he did not bequeath the sovereignty to him."[14]

This created a certain amount of dissension, but by 1229 the Mongols had agreed to recognize Ogodei as Genghis Khan's rightful successor. The new khan's first act was to dispatch forces westward. What Genghis Khan had seen as land to be raided, his sons saw as the new battlefront. And thanks to their father's training, they knew how to fight successfully against the settled west.